BEYOND CHIAVARI · FREE PLANNING KIT

# Outdoor Event Weather Plan

*A Chicago-area guide to seasons, tents, backup plans, and go or no-go decisions*

Chicago weather can change fast, and an outdoor event needs a plan for sun, rain, wind, and cold. This kit helps you choose a date and a tent, set a decision timeline, and make sure permits and utilities are handled well before the day.

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PART 1

# Chicago Seasons at a Glance

General seasonal patterns only. Weather varies year to year, so always check the forecast and talk to your rental company.

| Month | General pattern | Planning notes |
|---|---|---|
| January | Cold, snowy, and windy | Outdoor events are rare. Plan heated tents and snow removal if you must. |
| February | Cold with snow possible | Consider indoor venues. Heaters and sidewalls are essential if outdoors. |
| March | Cold to cool and changeable | Mud and thaw can affect tent installation and ground conditions. |
| April | Cool, often damp | Rain and chilly evenings are common. Plan covered space and heaters. |
| May | Mild, with rain and storms possible | Graduation season. Book tents early and plan for sudden showers. |
| June | Warm, with thunderstorms possible | Popular wedding and party month. Plan for shade and storm backups. |
| July | Hot and humid | Plan shade, fans, hydration, and cool seating. |
| August | Hot and humid, with storms | Heat management and storm plans matter for guests and food. |
| September | Warm to mild, often pleasant | Popular for events. Evenings can cool quickly. |
| October | Cool and crisp | Plan heaters, blankets, and wind protection. Early dark times. |
| November | Cold and damp, shorter days | Consider sidewalls and heaters. Plan lighting. |
| December | Cold and snowy | Plan snow removal, heaters, and warm drinks. |

PART 2

# Tent Decision Checklist

A tent is often the single best protection you can buy.

### DO YOU NEED A TENT?

- [ ] Is your event during a month with frequent rain or storms?
- [ ] Will the sun or heat be a concern for older guests or food?
- [ ] Is there a shaded or covered backup space nearby?
- [ ] Do you have a plan for wind, which can lift lightweight tents?
- [ ] Would guests be uncomfortable if you had to move the party in a hurry?
- [ ] Is the budget flexible enough to cover a tent as insurance?

### CHOOSING THE RIGHT TENT

- [ ] Estimate how many guests need cover at one time.
- [ ] Allow about 10 to 12 square feet per guest for seated dining and more for dancing.
- [ ] Choose a frame tent if staking is not allowed, or a pole tent where staking is allowed.
- [ ] Ask about sidewalls, clear walls, and heaters for cool weather.
- [ ] Ask about flooring options for uneven ground or mud.
- [ ] Plan for lighting, fans, and generators if needed.

### SITE CHECKS

- [ ] Measure the space, including clearances for trees, wires, and fences.
- [ ] Check the ground slope and drainage.
- [ ] Confirm that the rental company can access the site for delivery.
- [ ] Mark irrigation heads, sprinklers, and any underground items.
- [ ] Decide whether the tent needs stakes or weights.

PART 3

## Weather Plans by Condition

### RAIN PLAN

- [ ] Reserve a covered or indoor backup space.
- [ ] Arrange for tent sidewalls or a rain-ready configuration.
- [ ] Bring umbrellas, towels, and mats for entrances.
- [ ] Protect electronics and sound equipment.
- [ ] Plan for wet ground with flooring or pathways.
- [ ] Have a clear plan for who moves tables and decor.

### HEAT PLAN

- [ ] Provide shade, fans, and misting stations.
- [ ] Offer plenty of water and cool drinks.
- [ ] Place food on ice and limit time at room temperature.
- [ ] Schedule the event in the cooler part of the day.
- [ ] Plan seating in shaded areas for older guests and kids.
- [ ] Have sunscreen and cooling towels available.

### WIND PLAN

- [ ] Ask the rental company about anchoring and wind limits for your tent.
- [ ] Use heavy centerpieces and secure linens.
- [ ] Avoid tall, lightweight decor and balloon arches.
- [ ] Plan to lower tent sidewalls on the windy side.
- [ ] Know the wind speed that would trigger evacuation.

### COLD PLAN

- [ ] Rent heaters and verify fuel or power needs.
- [ ] Add tent sidewalls to keep wind out.
- [ ] Offer blankets, warm drinks, and hot food.
- [ ] Plan a coat check or coat area.
- [ ] Allow extra time for guests to arrive and warm up.

### STORM AND LIGHTNING PLAN

- [ ] Name a person who will make the call to move guests.
- [ ] Identify a sturdy indoor shelter, since tents do not protect from lightning.
- [ ] Watch radar apps and weather alerts during the event.
- [ ] Tell vendors and guests the plan before the party begins.
- [ ] Plan how to secure equipment quickly.

PART 4

## Go or No-Go Decision Timeline

Set your decision times in advance and tell your vendors.

| | |
|---|---|
| *8 to 12 weeks out* | ☐ Choose the date and reserve a tent and a backup option.<br>☐ Ask vendors about their weather policies and deadlines.<br>☐ Decide who has the authority to make weather calls.<br>☐ Write down your tent and no-go criteria, such as sustained wind or lightning risk. |
| *4 to 6 weeks out* | ☐ Confirm tent size, sidewalls, flooring, and heaters.<br>☐ Schedule a site visit with the rental company.<br>☐ Check permit requirements and utility locate needs.<br>☐ Share the backup plan with key helpers. |
| *7 to 10 days out* | ☐ Begin watching the long-range forecast.<br>☐ Confirm delivery and setup times.<br>☐ Confirm final headcount and layout.<br>☐ Prepare weather supplies like umbrellas, towels, and fans. |
| *3 to 5 days out* | ☐ Review the forecast and decide on tent add-ons such as sidewalls and heaters.<br>☐ Notify vendors about any plan changes.<br>☐ Tell guests about attire suggestions for the weather.<br>☐ Confirm that the backup space is ready. |
| *48 hours out* | ☐ Make the final go or no-go call on the outdoor plan.<br>☐ Confirm the plan with the caterer, DJ, and photographer.<br>☐ Send a short update to guests.<br>☐ Check that supplies are staged and accessible. |
| *Day of* | ☐ Check radar in the morning and at set intervals.<br>☐ Walk the site for puddles, debris, and hazards.<br>☐ Brief the helper team on the plan.<br>☐ Be ready to adjust the timeline if conditions change. |

PART 5

## Permits and Utility Reminders

Rules vary by city, village, and park district. Always confirm with the local office.

### PERMITS

- [ ] Ask your municipality whether a tent permit is required for the size you want.
- [ ] Ask about fire inspection requirements for tents and heaters.
- [ ] Check park district rules for reservations, amplified sound, and alcohol.
- [ ] Check whether street closures or parking permits are needed.
- [ ] Ask about noise ordinances and quiet hours.
- [ ] Allow plenty of lead time, since permits can take weeks.

### UTILITY LOCATES

- [ ] If the tent will be staked, call 811 a few days before installation to have underground utilities marked.
- [ ] Ask the rental company whether they will request locates or whether you must.
- [ ] Mark private lines such as irrigation, lighting, and invisible fences.
- [ ] Keep the locate ticket number for your records. Chicago and the surrounding suburbs use different locate services, so confirm which one applies to your address.
- [ ] Do not stake over marked lines.

### POWER AND SAFETY

- [ ] Calculate power needs for lights, heaters, fans, and sound.
- [ ] Use outdoor-rated extension cords and covers.
- [ ] Ask whether a generator is needed.
- [ ] Locate fire extinguishers and exits.
- [ ] Post a map of exits and a contact number.

PART 6

## Questions for Your Rental Company

1. What wind speed would cause you to recommend taking down or not installing the tent?
2. Can you stake on this surface, or do you use weights?
3. Do you request utility locates, or should I?
4. What is your cancellation or weather policy, and by when do I need to decide?
5. What sidewalls, heaters, fans, and flooring do you offer?
6. How early can you install the tent, and when will it be removed?
7. What is the capacity of the tent for dining versus standing?
8. Who do I call if there is a problem the night before or the morning of the event?

PART 7

## Weather Worksheet

EVENT DATE AND MONTH

LOCATION AND ADDRESS

EXPECTED GUEST COUNT

TENT SIZE AND TYPE

BACKUP SPACE

WEATHER DECISION MAKER

GO OR NO-GO DEADLINE

RENTAL COMPANY CONTACT

PERMIT OFFICE CONTACT

UTILITY LOCATE TICKET NUMBER

HEATER OR FAN NEEDS

GUEST NOTIFICATION PLAN

NEXT STEP

## Get every rental on one quote

Pick chairs, tables, linens, dinnerware, tents and decor from Chicago-area rental companies and see prices as you build your list at beyondchiavari.com/quote. Want a second set of eyes on your plan? Book a free planning call at beyondchiavari.com/book.

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